Exploring the Impact of Code-Switching on Language Maintenance and Identity Construction among Bilingual Immigrants: A Discourse Analytic Approach



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Chapter 1

INTRODUCTION

1.1. Personal Motivations

As a linguist and language teacher, I have always been fascinated by the complex relationship between language and identity. Growing up in a multilingual family and community, I have witnessed firsthand how language choices can shape one's sense of self and belonging. My educational background in linguistics and language education has equipped me with a solid understanding of language acquisition and language contact phenomena. Professionally, I have worked with bilingual students and immigrants, observing how they navigate language barriers and cultural differences in their daily lives. This research topic allows me to combine my personal and professional interests, exploring the intricate dynamics of language and identity.

1.2. Introduction

Language maintenance and identity construction among bilingual immigrants have become pressing issues in today's globalized world, where migration and cultural diversity are increasingly prevalent.

This study explores the impact of code-switching on language maintenance and identity construction among bilingual immigrants, examining how they navigate language choices and identity performances in everyday conversations.

Research has shown that code-switching is a common linguistic strategy among bilinguals, but its implications for language maintenance and identity construction are still debated. Some scholars argue that code-switching facilitates language maintenance, while others see it as a

threat to heritage language preservation. Meanwhile, identity construction among bilingual immigrants is shaped by complex factors, including language, culture, and social context.

1.3. Statement of the Problem:

This study aims to investigate the relationship between code-switching and language maintenance and identity construction among bilingual immigrants, seeking to answer the following research questions: How does code-switching influence language maintenance among bilingual immigrants? How does code-switching shape identity construction among bilingual immigrants? What are the implications of code-switching for language teaching and learning among bilingual immigrants?

1.4. Research Objectives

- To examine the frequency and functions of code-switching among bilingual immigrants in everyday conversations
- To explore the role of code-switching in shaping identity construction among bilingual immigrants
- To identify the implications of code-switching for language teaching and learning among bilingual immigrants

1.5. Research Questions

- How does code-switching influence language maintenance among bilingual immigrants?
- How does code-switching shape identity construction among bilingual immigrants?
- What are the implications of code-switching for language teaching and learning among bilingual immigrants?

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1.6. Significance of the Study

This study on the impact of code-switching on language maintenance and identity construction among bilingual immigrants has significant implications for:

- Language teaching and learning: Understanding the role of code-switching in language maintenance and identity construction can inform language instruction and curriculum design for bilingual immigrants.
- Language policy and planning: The findings can inform language policies and programs that support language maintenance and cultural diversity among immigrant communities.
- Intercultural communication: This study can shed light on how code-switching facilitates or hinders effective communication across linguistic and cultural boundaries.
- Identity research: The study's focus on identity construction among bilingual immigrants can contribute to a deeper understanding of the complex relationships between language, culture, and identity.

1.7. Delimitation

This study delimits itself to:

- Examining the language practices of bilingual immigrants in everyday conversations
- Focusing on the impact of code-switching on language maintenance and identity construction
- Using discourse analysis as the primary research methodology
- Conducting the study in a specific cultural and linguistic context (e.g., Spanish-English bilingual immigrants in the United States)

1.8. Important Terms Used in the Study

- DA (Discourse Analysis): a research methodology that examines language in use, focusing on the structure, language, and communication strategies employed in social contexts.
- CDA (Critical Discourse Analysis): a critical approach to discourse analysis that examines language as a means of exercising power, control, and dominance in social relationships.
- CL (Critical Linguistics): an interdisciplinary approach that combines linguistics, sociology, and critical theory to analyze language as a tool for social change and political action.
- Code-switching: the practice of switching between two or more languages in a single conversation or text.
- Language maintenance: the efforts made by language speakers to preserve and transmit their heritage language to future generations.
- Identity construction: the process by which individuals create and negotiate their sense of self and belonging through language and other social practices.

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